

Elite Purges: Internal Conflict or External Design?

Ishmael Kardryni

19 June 2025

Elite purges in authoritarian states are traditionally viewed as internal mechanisms of control: ruthless tools by which dictators consolidate power, eliminate dissent, and resolve factional disputes. However, history and contemporary events suggest a more complex interplay. These purges are not always endogenous phenomena; they are often instigated, influenced, or facilitated by external forces. The case of Albania under and after Enver Hoxha, and recent developments in Iran, highlight the blurred lines between domestic intrigue and foreign intervention.

Albania's history provides a powerful lens for understanding such strategies. Under Enver Hoxha, the country's internal purges were deeply entangled with its shifting foreign alliances. After breaking with the Soviet Union, Hoxha targeted the Soviet-educated elite, casting them as ideological threats. Later, as relations with Maoist China soured, Defense Minister Beqir Balluku was purged in 1974 under accusations of plotting a coup with Deng Xiaoping's moderates. Officially framed as a defense against foreign subversion, these actions reflected deeper geopolitical anxieties.

Some accounts suggest Greek intelligence played a role in exposing Soviet-backed conspiracies—perhaps inadvertently empowering Hoxha's campaign of internal repression. In 1962, Admiral Temo Sejko's execution followed similar claims of foreign entanglement, with Greece again cited as a source of intelligence for the Soviet conspiracy. Afraid of the Soviets, that shot down an airplane with Ramiz Alia's brother on board, Hoxha did not pursue the theory of the Soviet conspiracy. As he often did, he denounced the very Western secret services whose information he used, blaming them for the conspiracy.

Thus, external actors indirectly shaped the regime's repressive calculus and this pattern continued. In 1981, long-serving Prime Minister Mehmet Shehu, once Hoxha's heir apparent, was found dead—officially a suicide after being denounced as a "poly-agent" for Western and Eastern powers alike. The plausibility of such accusations aside, his fall aligned with the interests of foreign powers, particularly France and the U.S., who sought a softer post-Hoxha successor. Shehu's purge served both internal power consolidation and the preferences of external stakeholders.

After communism's collapse, the nature of purges changed, but their external dimensions re-

mained. In 1991, Sali Berisha led a technocratic faction that dismantled the old Politburo. While portrayed as democratic reform, it was in effect a foreign-backed elite replacement. Germany and the U.S., eager to integrate Albania into the Western bloc, supported this transition. Old-guard communists were imprisoned, but the action reflected global strategy as much as local reform.

In 1997, the pendulum swung again. Economic collapse triggered widespread unrest, and the Socialist Party—descendants of the old regime’s technocrats—ousted Berisha. He claimed foreign interference, especially from Greece, facilitated his fall. Whether true or not, the framing echoed earlier purges, where internal shifts masked international agendas.

These precedents are instructive for Iran’s case. The Islamic Republic has long struggled with generational and ideological divides. If the regime resists internal reform, external actors may intervene—directly or indirectly—to reshape the elite. While covert and overt Israeli, UK, and U.S. operations have so far failed to induce a gradual or revolutionary regime change, the Israeli strikes may now serve as a purge by proxy, eliminating entrenched figures and military infrastructure associated with the old guard. These actions function not only as military campaigns but as tools of strategic attrition aimed at reshaping the regime from without.

Yet this strategy is not guaranteed to succeed. Civilian casualties and foreign aggression often strengthen nationalist sentiment and consolidate internal power. Thus, what commentators interpret as Tehran’s restrained use of its anti-air missile arsenal in the aftermath of the June 13, 2025 attacks¹ may be part of a calculated response. In addition to preserving key defensive systems, Iran may be attempting to thwart regime-change narratives by projecting strategic patience, internal unity, and resistance to externally imposed fractures.

Whether internally initiated or externally induced, elite purges are not merely the outcome of domestic affairs. They also serve broader geopolitical designs. From Albania to Iran, the removal of ruling elites by decree, death, or foreign airstrike, are acts of statecraft in a global arena.

¹See Lars Lange, Telepolis. 19 Juni 2025. <https://www.telepolis.de/features/Irans-stumme-Luftabwehr-1-000-Batterien-null-Reaktion-10451681.html>